

You Are the Agent

ERA MINICON 2026 · ALYSSA ADAMS · BRING THIS, OR A NAPKIN

This is not a careers worksheet. A career is one of four gauges. Everything here is adapted from *Designing Your Life* (Burnett & Evans) — a design-school heuristic with a million readers and, honestly, no controlled trial. Use it because the structure is interesting. And play it as the agent from the talk's opening sim: one particle, two dials — outward sensing and inward sensing — swimming in a mixture you only partly chose. Each violet tag names the channel an exercise reads.

OUTWARD REACH

How far you sense other people's field.

BLIND

walks off alone, never comes back

EVERYONE

burrows in and stays

INWARD GAIN

How loudly you hear your own pace.

NUMB

the crowd sets your pace

DEAFENING

right in principle, wanders

Mark an **x** per track — today's setting, not the ideal one. The notch is the detent; these dials are live on slide 3.

1 Life dashboard — where are you actually? INWARD

Fill each gauge from empty to full. Don't overthink it; the first instinct is the data.

Health EMPTY FULL	Work EMPTY FULL	Play EMPTY FULL	Love EMPTY FULL
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2 Good Time Journal — five activities from last week INWARD + MEMORY

Real ones, with names. **Engagement and energy are different axes** — you can be completely absorbed and completely drained, and that combination is the most useful row on this page. One row is a scalar; five rows side by side are a gradient — the bacterium's trick, on paper.

ACTIVITY	ENGAGEMENT 0 → 5	ENERGY -3 → +3	FLOW?

3 AEIOU — on your highest-engagement row OUTWARD

Outward sensors, pointed at the moment the inward channel spiked: what was inside your radius?

- A** Activities — what were you *doing*? _____
- E** Environments — where, and how did it feel? _____
- I** Interactions — with people? systems? machines? _____
- O** Objects — what was in play? _____
- U** Users — who else, helping or hindering? _____

4 The question this whole exercise exists for BOTH CHANNELS

Find your lowest-energy activity. Who chose it?

Work the visible field rewards and the inward channel reads empty — the starving flock, in your handwriting.

An honest caveat. You just did this retrospectively, and retrospective recall of how things felt is biased — peak-end effects, mood-congruent recall, duration neglect. That is an argument for running the real version prospectively for two or three weeks. Not against the exercise.

Take it home

THE PARTS THAT NEED MORE THAN SEVEN MINUTES

5 The translation drill EMISSION

One sentence. No jargon. It has to survive being repeated by a hiring manager to their boss. You are not translating a *label* — you are naming a *method*. Other agents only sense what crosses into their radius; this sentence is what you emit.

I build / study _____
so that _____
can _____

6 Three futures — an abbreviated Odyssey Plan THREE MIXTURES

Hold all three in parallel. Do not rank them. In quality-diversity terms this is an archive of elites, and keeping the archive diverse is what makes the search find the good solution.

In the talk, one recipe ends as membrane, nucleus, or scattered — only the mixture differs. These cards are three mixtures for the same you: hold your parameters constant, let the mixture do the work.

A · What you're already doing

B · If that vanished tomorrow

Your subfield gets solved, defunded, or automated.

C · If money and other people's opinion were no object

If you only say one of these out loud, say C. It's the one nobody says.

7 Your compass — take an hour on these, separately YOUR RECIPE

Workview (~250 words): what is work *for*? Not what job you want. What defines worthwhile work? What does money have to do with it?

Lifeview (~250 words): what is a life for? What is the relationship between you and others? What is the role of joy, sorrow, love, strife?

Then read them side by side. Where do they clash? The compass is the *coherence*, not either document alone. This pair is your recipe — the steering numbers everything else swims by.

8 When to pivot INWARD · DERIVATIVE

The inward channel again, in derivative mode — read the rate, never the level.

Not when you're unhappy. Happiness is a noisy, slow, confounded signal.

Leave when your **rate of improvement** falls to the average rate available to you elsewhere. That's Charnov's marginal value theorem, 1976 — and note it's the *derivative*, not the level. Counterintuitively: **the richer the environment, the sooner you should leave.**

And when you go, **take your parts with you.** Across 58,000 startups, what separated eventual success from stagnation was *reuse* — the people who made it discarded less between attempts. Thrashing looks exactly like pivoting decisively.

9 If you read four things

- Liu, Dehmamy, Chown, Giles & Wang (2021) — hot streaks are preceded by exploration *then* exploitation. Neither half works alone. *Nature Communications* 12:5392 · doi.org/10.1038/s41467-021-25477-8
- Lazer & Friedman (2007) — densely connected groups converge fast on worse answers. *Admin. Science Quarterly* 52(4) · doi.org/10.2189/asqu.52.4.667
- Casciaro, Gino & Kouchaki (2014) — instrumental networking makes people feel dirty, and it's worse the less power you have. *ASQ* 59(4) · doi.org/10.1177/0001839214554990
- Stanley & Lehman (2015) — *Why Greatness Cannot Be Planned*. On serendipity, stepping stones, and why objectives deceive. Springer · doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-15524-1

The slides and all eight simulations are one HTML file — open it offline and drag the sliders; your two dials from page 1 are live controls on slide 3. · Anything the room invented in the niche-construction brainstorm goes to the ISAL board.